and district hospitals. ICs have to be set up in case they do not exist along with an all-round programme of sensitisation "of all government establishments on issues relating to women's safety" while urging private organisations to do the same.

To ensure the overall safety of health workers, the Indian Medical Association (IMA) has proposed that the draft it had prepared in 2019 after an assault on a doctor in Kolkata be turned into a legal ordinance. The draft had recommended imprisonment of up to 10 years and a fine of up to Rs 10 lakh for violence against doctors on duty. The Centre, too, had added an amendment to the Epidemic Diseases Act during the pandemic, which made violence against healthcare personnel a cognisable and non-bailable offence with imprisonment of up to seven years and a fine of up to Rs 5 lakh. The IMA has also recommended that the Code Grey protocol in practice in Kerala hospitals be extended to hospitals across the country. Code Grey alerts hospital staff to a dangerous or combative person in the hospital or criminal activity.

The Centre, meanwhile, has asked all government hospitals to register an institutional FIR within six hours of any incident of violence against an on-duty healthcare worker. This will ensure that the investigation can continue even after the original complainant may have shifted to another hospital. A few hospitals have been taking action on their own. AIIMS New Delhi, for instance, launched a safety app for its women employees in 2022. It provides details on the institute's IC and includes a panic button that sends a distress signal to the hospital security team. It also allows the security team to determine the user's location and respond quickly.

But some of the solutions being proffered in the current flurry have their own problems too. The West Bengal health department, for instance, has mandated that "working hours of women should not exceed 12 hours at a time. Wherever possible, night duty may be avoided for women to the extent possible". Not allowing women to work at night or limiting their working hours is restrictive and hinders their career growth. Instead, companies must create an enabling environment where women feel empowered. "It is about making space for safety, not just protection, because that will go a long way in getting women to work," says Kalpana Viswanath, co-founder and CEO of Safetipin, a social enterprise that uses technology to make urban spaces safer for women.

GETTING IT RIGHT

It could be something as simple as mobile phone apps that are connected to the travel desk or emergency response services or GPS trackers on cars that drop female employees home. At SAP Labs India, women employees working beyond 6 pm or before 6 am are provided a cab with a security guard who escorts them to their doorstep and waits until they are safely inside. Additionally, a designated security team member follows up with a call to ensure they have reached home safely,



"The MSMEs, which employ the largest number of women, have no mandatory compliance mechanism, only digital self-compliance"

— CORRINE KUMAR Founder, Vimochana, an NGO in Bengaluru



"The requirement for evidence in case of sexual harassment increases with the level of punishment, which means the person may get away completely. So, there should be some punishment, as that is also suffering"

— NANDITA SHAH Co-director & Managing Trustee, Akshara Foundation, Bengaluru

says their HR head Shweta Mohanty. Richard Lobo, chief people officer at IT firm Tech Mahindra, also emphasises the importance of group work during night shifts. "Even with security guards present, it's always safer and more effective for employees to work alongside their colleagues." He also suggests changing shift timings occasionally to ensure there is no fixed pattern to when employees arrive and leave the office.

Safety has to be ingrained in an organisation's culture, says Saundarya Rajesh, founder-president of DEI consulting firm Avtar Group. "Leaders have to articulate what they define as good behaviour." This is crucial because we are all products of the society we are born into, she asserts. If a person has witnessed violence at home, they see it as a norm, and could well carry it to the workplace. Hence, organisations must take a firm stand on what kinds of behaviour are acceptable and what aren't, emphasising the need for continuous employee training and sensitisation. Around 100 leaders at the contract food services provider Compass Group conduct nearly 360 'safety walks' yearly, during which they engage directly with employees on safety and harassment concerns.

Prevention is a key component of the PoSH Act, which mandates that employers conduct awareness programmes